

FIRE · CARBON & CLIMATE

Right-way fire and the carbon in the soil.

Two flux towers, side by side. One tells you what grazing does. The other tells you what law does.

On Turraburra, two flux towers stand on land that looks almost identical from a distance. One sits over paddock grazed the ordinary way. The other sits over Country burned and managed right-way, the Iningai way. For more than a year, both have been logging the same things — carbon, moisture, what the ground gives back and what it holds.

The two towers don't always agree.

When we did the soil testing, to go down and check out the soil — thirty centimetres down was where the carbon was starting. So therefore it wasn't sequestered.

Wrong-way fire — a hot burn, run without reading the ground first — leaves carbon sitting deep, doing nothing. Right-way fire works differently.

When we do a burn, we look for black ash, which is a biochar in its own right.

Within eight or nine months, the paddock had turned into a carbon sink.

This isn't a side project. Suzanne Thompson sits on the Commonwealth's Emissions Reduction Assurance Committee — the body that assesses and approves the methods used across the entire Australian Carbon Credit Unit scheme, the country's official carbon market.

She's the committee's first First Nations member, appointed specifically to help Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander communities take part in, and benefit from, a market most had been shut out of.

Because this space — them fella, they need our knowledge.

Her own framework for it goes further than carbon alone. She calls it Rainbow Carbon — the idea that restoration, biodiversity and cultural knowledge were never separate systems to begin with, and shouldn't be measured as if they are.

It's about our holistic land management practice of restoration of nature and sequestering carbon, which creates the unique, integral Indigenous carbon premium credit.

Western science can run its own tests alongside it. It usually agrees.

Two towers, side by side, logging the same ground. One of them just happens to be standing over land that's been read correctly for longer.

Suzanne Thompson, recorded on Country, 2026. Emissions Reduction Assurance Committee appointment confirmed via the Australian Government Department of Climate Change, Energy, the Environment and Water.